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Fallibilism and pentecostal theological epistemology

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ABSTRACT

This article explores the pertinence of fallibilism for Pentecostal theological epistemology. It begins by examining epistemological fallibilism as developed within the philosophy of science, particularly through the work by Charles S. Peirce. On this background, the discussion turns to three key themes: the nature of faith, Pentecostal experiences, and the potential ontological implications of fallibilism. Through an exploratory engagement with Pentecostal scholars, the article demonstrates how fallibilism can serve as a valuable resource for Pentecostal theological epistemology. Moreover, it argues that fallibilism extends beyond a purely epistemological concern, encompassing virtues that are vital for the broader Pentecostal philosophical and theological endeavour, including its scholarly community.

KEYWORDS

Fallibilism; faith; epistemology; experience; pragmatism; virtues

> Faith can take us to holy realms certainty can never reach. For centuries Christians have gathered to stand and confess the Nicene Creed, which begins with the words, 'We believe'. It's significant that it doesn't begin with, 'I'm certain that–' We've never been certain. Too much is at stake for that.[1]

Introduction

It is not controversial to assert that human beings are fallible – that we can and do make mistakes. In epistemological terms, this recognition is captured by the concept of fallibilism.[2] More precisely, fallibilism is the epistemological thesis that no belief – whether a theory, perception, or interpretation – can be justified in a conclusive or final manner. In other words, there is always a possible doubt associated with our knowledge. If this appears controversial at first glance, why, then, is it important to explore fallibilism in relation to Pentecostal epistemology?

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[1]Barnes, 'Having Faith in God is Better Than Being Certain about God'.

[2]Dahm, 'The Certainty of Faith', 130.

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It is necessary to address fallibilism within the framework of a Pentecostal epistemology. This need arises from the fact that Pentecostal epistemology often deals with faith in the tension between certainty and uncertainty. At the same time, Pentecostal epistemology seeks to resist various forms of relativism and skepticism. My question in this inquiry is how the notion of fallibilism can be meaningfully integrated into the Pentecostal epistemological endeavour. I will argue that fallibilism can serve as a constructive epistemological point of departure within a broader framework in which Pentecostal epistemology is situated. Rather than undermining faith, I also argue that fallibilism – understood as an epistemic virtue – can enrich Pentecostal reflection by fostering a theology that is both intellectually responsible and open to the dynamic, experiential nature of divine encounter.

My article is structured in three main parts. First, I analyse how fallibilism can be understood through the lens of Charles S. Peirce. His ideas originate in a scientific context and are developed within a broader philosophical framework of fallibilism. I consider it essential to provide a sufficiently comprehensive account of this background to ground the subsequent discussion. Second, I explore the relevance of fallibilism for Pentecostal epistemology by engaging with selected themes central for *Pentecostal theological epistemology*. This section draws on contributions from scholars within various Pentecostal traditions, as well as from scholars outside these traditions, whose insights help illuminate fallibilism within the scope of this article. Finally, I examine how fallibilism can be understood as a virtue within the Pentecostal theological epistemological endeavour.

As a preliminary clarification, it is important to note that there is no single, unified Pentecostal epistemology. In general terms, epistemology refers to the theory of knowledge and justification,[3] and it is possible to speak of multiple Pentecostal *epistemologies*.[4] Broadly speaking, the questions of interest for Pentecostal epistemologies often align with those addressed in the wider field of epistemology. However, I think that certain distinctive features characterize Pentecostal approaches. One such feature is that Pentecostal epistemology is not an isolated philosophical topic from which we start our inquiry and then moves into Pentecostal theology, as though the two were separate undertakings. Simo Frestadius makes a similar point, emphasizing that a Pentecostal epistemology must remain compatible with Pentecostal spirituality, beliefs, and

[3]Audi, *Epistemology*, 1.

[4]Such as James K. Smith's 'narrative epistemology', Stian Sørlie Eriksen's account that 'Pentecostals have centered on spiritual experience as an epistemological source for life and faith', and Simo Frestadius' notion of 'Pentecostal Biblical Pragmatism'. See Smith, *Thinking in Tongues*; Eriksen, 'The Epistemology of Imagination and Religious Experience'; and Frestadius, *Whose Pentecostalism? Which Rationality?* Other important works on Pentecostal epistemology are Yong, *Spirit-Word-Community*; Oliverio Jr, *Theological Hermeneutics in the Classical Pentecostal Tradition*; Wariboko, *The Pentecostal Hypothesis*, and Shin, *Pentecostalism, Postmodernism, and Reformed Epistemology*. On the emergence of Pentecostal epistemologies, see Andersen, *How to Understand Pentecostal Experiences*, 4ff.

practices.[5] In this view, epistemology, theology, and spirituality are deeply interwoven. For this reason, I find it appropriate to follow Christopher Stephenson, who coins the notion of *theological epistemology*.[6] This term captures the inseparability of epistemological and theological concerns within the Pentecostal context.

Fallibilism in science and philosophy

Peirce is widely recognized as the founder of pragmatism, although his successors, particularly William James, significantly developed the concept of 'pragmatism' within philosophy and made it well-known. Peirce's thinking is complex and somewhat obscure, especially his theory of signs. It is not without reason that Niels Christian Stefansen – in a somewhat amusing passage – describes it as a jungle of wildness through which no human has been able to find a path.[7] I will attempt to avoid getting lost in that jungle and following one path in Peirce's writings: his understanding of fallibilism, aware that this theme is reasonably interwoven with several others in Peirce's work.[8]

I find it useful to start with the context of natural sciences during Peirce's time, particularly because Peirce himself originally was a scientist (in chemistry). Nevertheless, it is his thinking on logic and philosophy that he considered his 'vocation' and that has established his legacy as the 'father of pragmatism'.[9] The prevailing scientific paradigm within the natural sciences during Peirce's time was early positivism. Auguste Comte argued that only scientific knowledge could be considered certain and valid knowledge. This knowledge of the world is obtained through the 'positively given'. We gain scientific (in the wide sense) knowledge only through positively given observations and empirical data, which allow us to generalize and formulate laws.[10]

It is interesting to note that Peirce developed his reflections on fallibilism during the last decade of the nineteenth century against the backdrop of this early positivist context, and not the later logical positivism of the Vienna Circle in the 1920s, which further developed positivism within a clearer framework of logic. Peirce was also an early advocate of the idea that philosophical activity must be grounded in logical inferences. However, in contrast to positivism, Peirce adopted and advocated a much broader approach to meaningful knowledge than the narrow positivist view.

Positivism's understanding of scientific endeavour is based on several epistemological premises. Peirce's development of fallibilism finds its place as a philosophical critique of one of these, empiricism. In addition, Peirce also critiques

[5]Frestadius, 'In Search of a "Pentecostal" Epistemology', 94.
[6]See Stephenson, *Types of Pentecostal Theology*, 3ff.
[7]Stefansen, 'Peirce: Pragmatismens stamfader', 413.
[8]We find some of the main sections on Peirce's fallibilism in Peirce, *Collected Papers*, 1.141–1.175.
[9]Burch, 'Charles Sanders Peirce'.
[10]Comte, *A General View of Positivism*, 1–7.

rationalism, in the Cartesian tradition, which also sought certain knowledge, but unlike empiricism, it claimed that we access it through reason.[11] Descartes' 'cogito ergo sum' precisely expresses the core of such certain knowledge.

This distinction between empiricism and rationalism is about what we consider as the *primary* resource in the process of cognition. Rationalism does not dismiss observations or empirical data *per se*, just as empiricism does not disregard the significance of thought in acquiring knowledge. Peirce's problem with both a strict empiricism and rationalism is that they express different foundationalist views of knowledge in terms of the ability to have secure knowledge. Thus, Peirce's critique is not about denying the role of our empirical experience or the significance of cognition,[12] but rather a critique of the understanding that one of these are the primary – and secure – resource in the process of gaining knowledge.

Foundationalism can take various forms, such as the distinction between strong and weak foundationalism.[13] These nuances are important, but my main point here is to highlight the more fundamental distinction between a foundationalist and a fallibilist account of knowledge. Within this context, one can speak of *epistemological foundationalism*. According to Wentzel van Huyssteen, foundationalism in this sense advocates that '… our beliefs can be warranted or justified by appealing to some item of knowledge that is self-evident or beyond doubt …'.[14] For Nancy Murphy, foundationalism might begin with certain doctrinal beliefs regarded as fundamental in the sense that they are self-supporting and require no further justification.[15] Peirce's critique of epistemological foundationalism, along with that of later pragmatists like Nicholas Rescher, is that it does not emphasize the provisional nature of knowledge. Additionally, the notion of provisional knowledge in fallibilism also stands in opposition to scepticism and relativism.[16]

Contrasting fallibilism with scepticism is necessary because it has often been interpreted as a form of scepticism. While fallibilism emphasizes the provisionally character of knowledge, scepticism – at least in its more radical forms – questions the possibility of objective knowledge altogether. In the words of Peirce, there is a world of difference between fallible knowledge and no knowledge.[17] Scepticism, in this sense, tends toward nihilism by being fundamentally critical of and doubt all aspects of gaining knowledge. In this sense, scepticism's position is of a somewhat static character. In contrast, Peirce claims that truth actually exists. Through our inquiry, we are participating in a forward-moving

[11]Potter, *Peirce's Philosophical Perspectives*, 141.
[12]Peirce, *Collected Papers*, 2.444; 5.50.
[13]Audi, *Epistemology*, 193–95.
[14]van Huyssteen, *Essays in Postfoundationalist Theology*, 226.
[15]Murphy, *Reasoning and Rhetoric in Religion*.
[16]It is also possible to make other contrasts with foundationalism, such as with coherentism, in the sense that beliefs can only be justified via other beliefs. Additionally, it is possible to consider types of middle ways between these two. See Rescher, *Cognitive Pragmatism*, 21ff.
[17]Peirce, *Collected Papers*, 1.37.

process towards truth. The research process itself is therefore crucial, as expressed in Peirce's famous: 'Do not block the way of inquiry'.[18]

Therefore, an important feature of Peirce's thinking on fallibilism is his concern with the process of inquiry rather than knowledge itself.[19] This highlights the dynamic character of Peirce's epistemology. His fallibilism entails a dynamic, open-ended, experimental, explorative, and playful search for knowledge.[20] These qualities are not merely epistemological 'exercises' because his fallibilism is a natural part of how we *think* as human beings and is thus a universal trait of human reasoning. Moreover, fallibilism is justified in our tension between past and the future. The uncertainty of our access to certain knowledge of both the past and the future should make us humble regarding our present current knowledge. This is especially relevant when considering our knowledge of the future, which, as Rescher aptly puts it: 'The details of the cognitive future are hidden in an impenetrable fog'.[21]

On the other hand, fallibilism has been accused of supporting relativism because it does not endorse various types of foundationalism. Relativism can take many forms, but in this context it refers to the idea that all knowledge claims is somehow equally valid or that all truths are equal.[22] However, this criticism is also misplaced, and Peirce rejects such position.[23] As Andy F. Sanders has pointed out, fallibilism is a middle way between relativism and foundationalism. It avoids self-defeat because, unlike epistemological foundationalism, it acknowledges that its own position can be fallible.[24] On the basis of this exploration of fallibilism, I will now turn my attention to Pentecostal theological epistemology and fallibilism.

Pentecostal theological epistemology and fallibilism

As previously noted, it would be an oversimplification to speak of a singular, unified Pentecostal theological epistemology – understood as if there is a genuine acquisition of knowledge in a Pentecostal approach that either supports or is challenged by a fallibilist view of knowledge. Instead, it is more fruitful to address how the general thesis of fallibilism might function within a Pentecostal theological epistemology. This approach allows for a more nuanced engagement with selected features and themes of Pentecostal theology in which questions related to fallibilism arises.

It is important to emphasize that these themes are not necessarily 'unique' to Pentecostal theology. Rather, they are broadly situated within the wider

[18]Peirce, *Collected Papers*, 1.135. See also Haack, 'Do Not Block the Way of Inquiry', 319–39.
[19]Peirce, 'The Scientific Attitude and Fallibilism', 42ff.
[20]Sæther, 'The Many Faces of Fallibilism', 21.
[21]Rescher, *Cognitive Pragmatism*, 64.
[22]Hastings and Sæther, 'A Fallibilist Approach in the Age of COVID-19 and Climate Change', 2.
[23]Potter, *Peirce's Philosophical Perspectives*, 142.
[24]Sanders, 'Dogmatism, Fallibilism and Truth'.

Christian theological interpretive framework. Nevertheless, certain features within Pentecostal theology make these themes as central for identifying its distinctiveness. In this exploration, Pentecostal theologies which are inspired by pragmatism – such as those developed by Amos Yong and Simo Frestadius – will serve as key dialogue partners. First, I will examine 'the nature of faith'. Second, I will address the question of Pentecostal experiences and fallibilism. Finally, I will explore how fallibilism can provide resources for Pentecostal theological epistemology when moving from epistemology to ontology. This final move is of particular interest, as I argue that critical realism provides a fruitful taken position that affirms that the process of gaining knowledge (epistemology) reflects something of the way reality actually is (ontology).

The nature of faith and pentecostal theological epistemology

A central question within Pentecostal theological epistemology concerns the nature of faith. Reflecting on the nature of faith is, of course, a topic for any faith tradition and theology that seeks to articulate the distinctive qualities of Christan faith. The notion of 'nature of faith' belongs, in my view, to a context where philosophical themes such as rationality, science, and knowledge are pertinent. I will highlight a few perspectives.

One dimension relates to how faith is expressed through doctrinal statements. This is evident in several Pentecostal traditions, such as the Pentecostal European Fellowship.[25] Doctrinal statements of faith have been understood as theological foundations, understood as fundamental dogmas that are self-supporting and regarded as true.[26] There is not enough space here for a discussion of such truth statements, but their fallible status invites reflection. Frestadius observes that doctrinal statements, exemplified by Elim's foundational truths, have been revised and can be revised.[27] Therefore, it is inappropriate to consider them as infallible documents in a foundational, non-negotiable, sense. From the standpoint of epistemic foundationalism, one might argue that such beliefs are not truly foundational but rather depend – at least to some extent – on other beliefs which do not require further justification. Nevertheless, I regard these truth statements as aligning with Murphy's interpretation of foundationalism, in which they possess a doctrinal character.

In addition to such historical reasons of the fallibility of truth statements, there are more underlying reasons for fallibilism relevant for Pentecostal theological epistemology. Yong points out – within a larger picture of Pentecostal rationality – that knowledge is partial for several reasons.[28] One is that our knowledge is partial because we are limited human beings. Another is that

[25]See 'Statement of Faith', Pentecostal European Fellowship.
[26]On foundationalism in this sense, see for example Murphy, *Reasoning and Rhetoric in Religion*, 239–40.
[27]Frestadius, *Pentecostal Rationality*, 110–13; 203.
[28]Yong, 'Fallibilism', 53ff.

we do not have any direct, immediate intuitions concerning perceptual facts; there is always a distance between the knower and the object. In addition, we will always acquire knowledge within given frameworks of biological, geographical, and socio-cultural nature.

Yong further argues that knowledge is mediated through others or mediated by faith. In terms of theology, the ultimate 'object,' God, is without analogy (Ps. 86:8 and Is. 45–47). Yet, theological knowledge is pneumatologically mediated. Moreover, knowledge is partial since it is semiotic in nature and the very fabric of reality contributes to its incompleteness. Hence, we find an ontological basis for the epistemological incompleteness of our knowledge. In summary, two main points for fallibilism is highlighted by Yong: Our knowledge is incomplete, and error is possible.

Yong's solution is to emphasize – with reference to Acts 2 – that knowledge of the infinite God 'resounds in and through the many voices and perspectives'.[29] The many perspectives, conveyed through the Gospels, Pauline literature, and early Christian history, contribute to a richer understanding of any particular 'theological phenomena'. This knowledge has a teleological dimension. Furthermore, we can attain true knowledge because there is *not* a complete disconnection or insurmountable distance between the knower and the known.

Does endorsing a fallibilist stance in a Pentecostal theological epistemology imply a fundamental uncertainty regarding the validity of faith? This question invites deeper problematization of the nature of faith itself. Is it not the case that faith is inherently accompanied by a sense of certainty, thereby justifying the notion of 'certainty of faith'?[30] Drawing on Evan Howard, Yong addresses this tension by distinguishing between moral certainty and absolute certainty: 'We can know in our heart, bodies, and habits enough to act responsibly, and these can be modified as needed and so long as we remain open to such rectification'.[31] In this way, Yong demonstrates that a moral certainty of faith in a sense goes deeper and is consistent with fallibilism.

At the heart of my problematization is the tension between the *rationality of faith* and *faith as mystery*. Although mystery is a complex notion, the tension seems clear. The nature of faith has a rationale, yet faith is also a mystery – something we cannot fully grasp. It is within this tension that the nature of faith finds its place. Hence, faith is expressed precisely as 'the assurance of things hoped for, and the conviction of things not seen'.[32] In such a tension, it is not a given that it is possible to separate what is rational from what is mysterious. The nature of faith has this quality where these two are inextricably intertwined. However, if the dynamics between the rationality of faith and

[29]Ibid., 59.
[30]See Dahm, 'The Certainty of Faith', 130.
[31]Yong, 'Fallibilism', 61.
[32]Heb 11.1. KJV. Also see Murray, 'Fallibilism, Faith and Theology', 343.

the mystery of faith are also a mystery, one might be led to conclude that the nature of faith remains cloudy. I do not believe this is the case.

In light of fallibilism, we also must acknowledge that human knowledge is marked by sin.[33] For Yong, it is not entirely adequate to speak of error in this context; rather, he advocates an epistemic fallibilism in moral terms. Nevertheless, the fallen state of creation points forward to the eschaton, as Yong points out with reference to Paul in Romans, as we await adoption – the redemption of our bodies. I find the theological notion of God's kingdom as arrived through Jesus Christ, and present with the Spirit, yet not fully present ('already but not yet') helpful. It takes seriously both the limitedness of human beings *and* the unlimitedness of God through his providence. We exist in this in-between state of the earthly and the eternal. According to Yong, we can trust that 'our fallible judgements can nevertheless, by and through the divine Spirit, guide faithful discipleship'.[34] Therefore, faithful discipleship indicates a direction forward by the Spirit's guidance, so the nature of faith does not remain stuck in a 'cloudiness'.

Finally, the nature of faith has a *forward-reaching dimension*. Paul Murray argues that faith is not arrived at as the logical endpoint of a reasoning process with certainty:

> As in love and ethical awakening, so faith certitude is best thought of as the conviction of being grasped by a reality that evokes one's trust while itself in turn eluding one's own grasp and the giving of cast-iron guarantees.[35]

This resonates with the Anselmian notion of *fides quaerens intellectum*, which is not about faith seeking understanding for secure knowledge, but about an explorative search for deeper insight and understanding. In conclusion, the nature of faith is a phenomenon where 'knowledge, belief, certainty, and uncertainty are intertwined in a mysterious way, as the true object of theology, God, is a mystery; revealed, yet hidden'.[36] From these explorations of the nature of faith, I now turn to Pentecostal experiences and fallibilism.

Pentecostal experiences and fallibilism

The American Baptist preacher A.J. Gordon, as referred to by Frestadius, argues, 'experience is the surest touchstone of truth. It is not always infallible [but] this is a kind of testimony which is not easily ruled out in court.'[37] As for the holiness tradition and later Pentecostalism, experience is at the core of theology. I approach the notion of Pentecostal experience in line with Andersen, who asserts that using the term 'Pentecostal experiences' refers to a specific

[33]Yong, 'Fallibilism', 63.
[34]Ibid., 64.
[35]Murray, 'Fallibilism, Faith and Theology', 343.
[36]Sæther, 'The Many Faces of Fallibilism', 29.
[37]Frestadius, *Pentecostal Rationality*, 79.

type of religious experiences. These are 'Christian experiences with a specific content or object (the triune God) understood in a particular "confessional" way'.[38] However, experience is a highly slippery term, even when narrowed to Pentecostal contexts.[39] Despite its slipperiness, the importance of the experiential dimension in Pentecostal theology – and spirituality – cannot be underestimated.[40] Pentecostalism's early identity was shaped by a spirituality that arises from (charismatic) experiences of the Divine, and its continued growth and global influence have this as a significant distinctive feature.[41]

One approach to experiences and fallibilism is found in Frestadius' analysis of experiences exemplified within the Foursquare Elim tradition. Frestadius analyses Elim's pragmatic epistemology by drawing on resources from William P. Alston. Alston argues that that religious experiences can be understood as either direct or indirect awareness of God. Such experiences are not solely subjective feelings or sensations, as individuals 'report an experiential awareness of God'.[42] There seems to be a mystical perception of a transcendent reality. The relevance for fallibilism is clear. How can one discern between genuine encounters with the Divine and those that are not, considering that we can be mistaken?

Frestadius shows that there are various views of the epistemic dimension of experiences. He demonstrates that within the Elim tradition, there is a more direct understanding of awareness and encounter with God. This more direct and non-mediated awareness seems to differ from Yong's perspective, where knowledge is always mediated. Knowledge and experiences are interwoven, as experiences can be understood as mediating factual insight and knowledge, or even stronger expressed by W.G. Hathaway as giving direct access to the Divine mind.[43] Because what is conveyed is from God, one might think that a purely subjectivist interpretation of experience is avoided. However, such 'direct access' does not steer clear hermeneutical challenges. Is not the case that all experiences are subject to a degree of interpretation, where pre-understanding and prejudice in a hermeneutical sense are included? Such a hermeneutic context will therefore be an interpretative space, where the potential for misunderstanding and error occur.

Theologically, the fallibility of interpreting experiences of the Divine adds another dimension to the discussion. Frestadius addresses this challenge by addressing the role of sin in terms of fallen humanity, and how it limits the capacity to form accurate theological beliefs. This indicates that the interpretation of Pentecostal experiences must be viewed in light of the condition of

[38]Andersen, *How to Understand Pentecostal Experiences*, 16.
[39]The term 'experience' is a topic I will not be addressing in detail here. See Andersen, *How to Understand Pentecostal Experiences,* 16.
[40]See e.g. Andersen who elaborates on this. Andersen, *How to Understand Pentecostal Experiences*, 8ff.
[41]See e.g. Cox, *Fire from Heaven*, and Dempster, *et al*., *The Globalization of Pentecostalism.*
[42]Alston referred in Frestadius, *Pentecostal Rationality*, 194.
[43]Frestadius, *Pentecostal Rationality*, 196.

sin as they will have limitations and can even be mistakenly interpreted as encounters with the Divine. Yet this condition is not all that can be said as we might consider understanding Pentecostal experiences with a different emphasis than what initiated or produced the belief. Based on what Frestadius describes as Elim's empirical experimentalism, the focus is not 'what produced the belief', but 'what the belief produces', in terms of emphasizing the results of faith. Frestadius relates such an approach to the philosophical pragmatism of Peirce and James. Hence, in this sense, the justification of beliefs and experiences is a pragmatic one.

In order to justify certain experiences, there must be some 'internal criteria' – such as those in the Elim tradition. For Frestadius, these criteria are marked by pragmatism and coherentism. Therefore, a type of *pragmatic coherentism* is employed to evaluate the experiences.[44] To discern between contradictory experiences the Elim tradition has used the Bible and doctrine, and pointed out that experiences are known by their fruits.[45] Underlying these 'internal criteria', I find the context of the interpretative Christian community to be important. Hence, there is a hermeneutical community that collectively engages in the evaluation of experiences and their potential fallibility within the framework of this Pentecostal tradition.

By acknowledging fallibilism, the role of experiences in Pentecostal theological epistemology can emphasize a community-based biblical hermeneutics for the discernment of experiences. Such a hermeneutics involves a serious engagement with Scripture, ensuring that experiences are consistent with the Bible. At the same time, it must acknowledge the Spirit's guidance and recognize that the interpreters are always situated within cultural and social contexts.[46]

Following this line of thought, the interpretive community appears to hold priority and takes to a certain degree precedence in discerning experiences. This leads us to identify the characteristics of such a community. As I read Yong, such a community does not collectively have a unison interpretation but instead express 'the many tongues,' allowing for nuances in how experiences are discerned. Emphasizing the role of the community in this way, underscores the importance of broadening the discussion of fallibilism. More specifically, I propose that fallibilism should be reflected upon in terms of certain virtues. I will return to this in the final part. Furthermore, the contributions of Yong and Frestadius on the nature of faith and experience provide valuable resources for exploring the potential connections between epistemology and ontology as constructive elements for Pentecostal theology.

[44]Ibid., 204.
[45]Ibid., 203.
[46]We find these dimensions of hermeneutics also developed by Kenneth Archer in his triadic hermeneutics: the Holy Spirit, the biblical text, and the (Pentecostal) community. See Archer, *A Pentecostal Hermeneutic*.

Explorations from epistemology to ontology: towards eschaton

The fallibilism I have unpacked so far pertains to epistemological fallibilism. When our knowledge has a verisimilitude character, how can this provide insights into the nature of reality? Underlying such an approach, I find fallibilism as a dimension embedded within a framework of critical realism. Although critical realism can be developed differently, the 'critical' in critical realism finds its way between naïve realism and constructivism. The critical aspect addresses the epistemological component acknowledging the fallibility of human knowledge and affirming that our achievements are approximations of truth.[47] The realist component of critical realism asserts that reality exists independently of human cognition. As such, critical realism maintains that ontology controls epistemology.[48] With critical realism as a taken position, I will – albeit cautiously – offer reflections on fallibilism based on the relationship between epistemology and ontology, with an eye toward Pentecostal theology.

If we follow John Polkinghorne's critical realism – that epistemology mirrors ontology – it follows that our current knowledge, along with the process of inquiry itself, reflects something of the nature of reality (the ontological claim). This thought resonates with Peirce's thinking, where we also find a similar connection between epistemology and ontology. In Peirce's tychism, which posits that absolute chance is an ontological real quality in the world, such chance expresses a dynamically evolving reality.[49] This ontological openness is interwoven with the fallibilism of inquiry, as Robert Burch notes: 'Reference to his tychism provides an added reason for Peirce's insisting on the irreducible fallibilism of inquiry'.[50] There are some challenges in this understanding of the transition between epistemology and ontology that I must set aside for now. My point is to explore a possible connection, where knowledge comes to us as novelty, and novelty in this context is related to both epistemology and ontology.

Yong develops similar thoughts by drawing on Whitehead's process philosophy. Yong argues that a dynamic understanding of reality supports the fallibility of our knowledge about this reality: 'Given this shift to ontology of becoming, the fluid nature of thought and language is assumed to reflect the dynamic nature of reality itself'.[51] For Yong, there is a relationship between the ontological claim about the dynamic character of reality and epistemological fallibilism: 'The dynamism of reality means that knowledge is itself dynamic and partial … '[52] With reference to Eph. 3.20, Yong emphasizes that this is

[47]Polkinghorne, *Belief in God*, 104. See also Hastings and Sæther, 'A Fallibilist Approach in the Age of COVID-19 and Climate Change', 1ff.
[48]Polkinghorne, 'The Quantum World', 335.
[49]Peirce, 'The Scientific Attitude and Fallibilism', 364.
[50]Burch, 'Charles Sanders Peirce'.
[51]Yong, 'Fallibilism', 56.
[52]Ibid., 56.

particularly true for theological knowledge because God is 'able to accomplish abundantly far more than all we can ask or imagine'.[53] Theological knowledge is eschatological in nature because it unfolds progressively in space–time toward the eschaton. Such an ontology is therefore not static but is an ontology of 'true becoming'.

A reality of true becoming can be supported by the notion of chance. Chance, as formulated by Peirce and echoed in broader reflections on the interplay between chance and necessity, is an ontological quality of nature.[54] This view is also developed by Polkinghorne, but he relates both change and necessity as relevant for the theological discourse.[55] It is important to emphasize that chance as a quality in the world does not mean blind or aimless development. Rather, it can be interpreted in terms of openness, freedom, contingency, and novelty. The very realization of the universe's anthropic fertility is contingent upon the interplay between chance and necessity where the latter is understood as lawfulness and regularities in the world. On this basis, Polkinghorne suggests that we can 'look for God's presence in the historical contingency as well as in the regularity (necessity) of what is happening'.[56]

This perspective opens for creative explorations in theology, particularly at the intersection of epistemology and ontology through the lens of novelty. In one sense, novelty comes from God. God's interaction with creation is expressed through history, revealing a God who acts and engages. Furthermore, knowledge comes 'from' God and is mediated to fallible human beings. The eternal intersects with the temporal and limited and the infinite engages the finite. Hence, reality is a dynamic reality of true becoming oriented toward a telos.

Moreover, the nature of Christian faith involves the dynamics of assurance/hope and conviction/not seen. This dynamic resonates within a Pentecostal ontology, such as developed by Yong. However, this intersection of epistemology and ontology within a Pentecostal theological epistemology – particularly in the context of fallibilism – requires further exploration.

Nevertheless, there is a theological eschatological dimension of knowing. In Paul's words: 'we see through a glass, darkly; but then face to face: now I know in part; but then shall I know even as also I am known'.[57] And at the end of time – with God – what remains of epistemology? Somewhat unguarded, we might say that epistemology, in one sense, collapses into ontology as in an Omega-point, to use a phrase from Pierre Teilhard de Chardin,[58] or more aptly in the words of Paul: 'that God may be all in all'.[59] This vision marks the final

[53]Ibid., 56.
[54]Peirce, *Collected Papers*, 6.36–6.43.
[55]Polkinghorne, *Science and Creation*, 47.
[56]Polkinghorne, *Science and Theology,* 84.
[57]1 Cor 13.12 KJV.
[58]Teilhard de Chardin, *Le Phénomèn Humain*, 287.
[59]1 Cor 15.28 KJV.

end of fallibilism. A Pentecostal interpretation of such a forward-moving understanding toward eschaton must emphasize the return of Christ as an important part of this future narrative.

Fallibilism as attitude and virtue

In my final section, I will make a shift in my approach to fallibilism, though related to parts of the preceding discussion. I find fallibilism not only as a topic within the context of epistemology related to the pursuit of knowledge; it also pertains to a given condition in our attempt to orient and understand the world where we cultivate certain attitudes – virtues – that are essential for developing and practicing Pentecostal theology and spirituality.

Fallibilism as a virtue does not refer to a different type of fallibilism than the one I have explored above as an epistemological fallibilism. Epistemological fallibilism – as developed so far – and fallibilism as a virtue find a common ground in the notion of 'epistemic virtues'. Fallibilism as a virtue can be linked to what James A. Montmarquet refers to as epistemic virtues in relation to personal qualities.[60] He particularly emphasizes one: 'epistemic conscientiousness'. This involves striving to achieve truth and avoid falsehood. However, Montmarquet argues that this must be cultivated in a community where we, in our pursuit of understanding, must learn from others and remain open to the possibility that we may be wrong. Such fallibilism, therefore, involves a specific attitude of awareness.

Peirce's fallibilism can also be interpreted as an 'attitude'.[61] For him, this attitude is not confined to researchers in specific fields but applies broadly to all knowledge acquisition within the scientific community. When fallibilism is understood as a given condition, our quest for understanding *should* incorporate this inherent fallibility as a virtue within our actual research practices. Therefore, we can argue that our awareness involves attitudes and normative questions within the research community itself.[62] Robin W. Lovin, *et al.*, in their discussion of interdisciplinary research, describe the qualities of a healthy research community in terms of 'habits of mind' and 'interdisciplinary virtues'.[63] While my intention is not to discuss interdisciplinarity *per se*, I wish to highlight that certain virtues should be cultivated within the community of Pentecostal scholars.

One such virtue is *humility*. Alessandra Tanesini associates humility with fallibilism.[64] For Tanesini, fallibilism is primarily a feature of epistemic agents, and humility naturally follows from a fallibilist position.[65] Therefore, it

[60]Montmarquet, 'Epistemic Virtues', 116–17.
[61]Peirce, 'The Scientific Attitude and Fallibilism', 42.
[62]Sæther, 'Når forskningskulturer møtes', 78.
[63]Lovin, *et al.*, 'Theology as Interdisciplinary Inquiry', xxix.
[64]Tanesini, 'Virtues, Emotions, and Fallibilism', 67. See also Sæther, 'The Many Faces of Fallibilism', 29–30.
[65]Tanesini, 'Virtues, Emotions, and Fallibilism', 70.

makes sense to speak of *epistemic humility*. Within the research community, humility fosters awareness of one's own academic assumptions – their possibilities and limitations – and encourages respect for the perspectives of others. However, to show respect is one thing, another is to be open for and challenged by the insights of others.

Naturally, as individual scholars we start from our own field of study. However, this can sometimes be limiting if we are unable – or unwilling – to venture beyond those boundaries. For creative interaction among researchers to occur, a certain degree of *openness* is essential. In this context, openness covers at least two dimensions; first, openness to the possibility that one's own assumptions may be mistaken; and second, openness to insights from other disciplines and traditions. This is not a simple or effortless task, as Stroeber expresses it: 'When new ideas and ways of thinking did not fit fairly easily into their own cognitive structures, they [scholars] shut them out'.[66] Openness is closely linked to *curiosity*, both the curiosity that drives one's own research and the curiosity that extends beyond it. Understandably, such openness may challenge and reshape scholarly discussion on theological topics. Yet openness does not entail a relativization of core convictions. Rather, it is a foundational virtue in scholarly engagement – an acknowledgement that one can learn something new, deepen one's understanding, and engage in a reflective process.

Perceptiveness is present in all scholarly inquiry, yet bias – which we all possess – is unavoidable. What becomes particularly significant, then, is our attitude toward our own fallibility. This recognition leads naturally to a reflection on the virtues we uphold in our interactions with others. It becomes evident that humility, openness, and curiosity should be fundamental virtues in any Pentecostal theological endeavour. How these virtues can be cultivated and integrated into reflections on Pentecostal theological epistemology remains an important area for further exploration.

Overall, the assessments made in this article points out that epistemic fallibilism is a given condition that must be acknowledged in Pentecostal theological epistemology. My exploration demonstrates that insights from epistemic fallibilism contribute meaningfully to discussions on the topics of the nature of faith, experience, the intersection between epistemology and ontology. Recognizing the inherent limitations of human knowledge opens the door to a complementary dimension: fallibilism as a virtue, where the virtues of humility, openness, and curiosity have been highlighted. These explorations can initiate further discussions on fallibilism, enabling the development of a rich and grounded epistemology while taking seriously the distinctive character of Pentecostal theological epistemology.

[66]Strober, *Interdisciplinary Conversations*, 4.

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